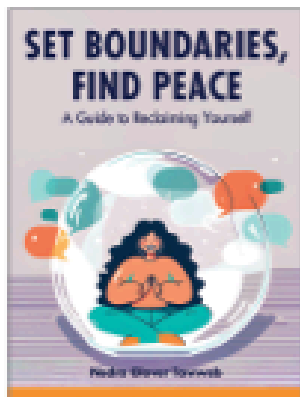




SET BOUNDARIES, FIND PEACE

A Guide to Reclaiming Yourself

Nedra Glover Tawwab



The Big “So What”

In this book, licensed therapist Nedra Tawwab explains what boundaries are, and how you can establish healthy boundaries to enhance your relationships and well-being. These insights are valuable for anyone seeking to enhance their mental-emotional wellness, or to overcome codependency, power struggles, anxiety, depression, or burnout.



Introduction



Boundaries define roles, expectations, and acceptable behaviors in relationships. They ensure that your needs and expectations are met, and you feel secure and comfortable in your relationships.

- As a therapist, Tawwab finds that one of the most common problems in relationships and mental health issues is the lack of clear boundaries. Often, we don't set boundaries for fear of upsetting others. Yet, the lack of boundaries leads to draining, one-sided, or even abusive relationships. These create mental, emotional, and physical pain, exhaustion, or burnout.
- It's better to face the short-term discomfort of setting boundaries, than to pay the long-term price of unhealthy and dysfunctional relationships.



In this book, Tawwab discusses many overlapping ideas about boundaries over 15 chapters. We've distilled and organized the key ideas into 2 parts in this summary:

- Understanding Boundaries: What they are and why they matter.
- Implementing Boundaries: How to set and maintain healthy boundaries.

KEY QUOTES

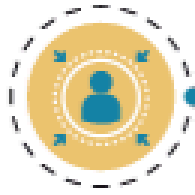
"This book will...give you the confidence and courage to create healthy boundaries in your own life."

"People don't know what you want. It's your job to make it clear. Clarity saves relationships."

"Set a boundary or suffer the consequences of not setting one."

"Boundaries will set you free."

"Boundaries are the gateway to healthy relationships."



Understanding Boundaries



Types of boundaries and where they come from



Broadly, there are 3 types of boundaries:

- Porous boundaries are vague or ill-defined. You often say “yes” when you want to say “no,” leading to overexertion, anxiety, and unhealthy relationships. Common signs include: emotional entanglement, fear of rejection or disapproval, oversharing, people-pleasing, over-reliance on external validation, and even tolerating abuse.
- Rigid boundaries are strict rules intended for self-protection. However, you may end up shutting people out, disregarding others’ needs and feelings, and isolating yourself. Signs include: distancing yourself, having unreasonable expectations, refusing to share or compromise even when it’s necessary.
- Healthy boundaries are based on self-awareness, not emotional baggage. You know your physical, mental and emotional capacity, and can communicate your needs and expectations clearly to balance intimacy and a healthy sense of self. Signs include: clarity of values, appropriate sharing, willingness to be vulnerable with those you trust, and the ability to say and accept “no.”



You cannot build a healthy relationship with rigid or porous boundaries. Here are several signs that you need clear boundaries.

- Self-neglect: You prioritize others’ needs over your own, to the point your physical, mental, and emotional well-being suffers.
- You feel perpetually overwhelmed and often wish to escape it all. Yet, you keep trying to add more to your endless to-do list.
- You feel angry, frustrated and resentful of others’ requests because you feel underappreciated and exploited. Your anger might be directed inwardly (e.g. self-blame) or outwardly (e.g. tantrums or apathy) to hurt your relationships and mental health.

KEY QUOTES

“Boundaries are not walls. A wall keeps people out, while boundaries show people how to exist in a relationship with you.”

“If you learn to pay attention to your body, it will tell you when it’s time to set boundaries.”

- You avoid certain people so they can't load you with new requests, e.g. you avoid picking up their calls or postpone/cancel your meetings in hopes that person/problems will just go away.
- You experience mental health issues like severe anxiety or symptoms of burnout.

Why We Fail to Set Boundaries

 There are several obstacles to boundary-setting:

- Thinking that the problem lies with others and waiting for them to change. In reality, you have the power to change your relationship dynamics.
- Giving up prematurely after failed attempts to set boundaries in the past.
- Lack of self-awareness: You don't realize that your feelings of resentment, frustration, or exhaustion are signs that you need clearer boundaries.
- Imagining the worst, then holding back because you're afraid of failure, rejection, confrontation, discomfort, appearing mean/rude, or causing awkwardness.

 Our perceptions and approach to boundaries are influenced by many factors, including our personality, families, teachers, peers, and mass media.

- Our first lessons on boundaries come from our families, especially the rules and limits set by our parents. If your family members often dismissed or disrespected boundaries, then you might find it harder to assert your own boundaries.
- Childhood issues can greatly impact our ability to set boundaries. These include physical/emotional abuse or neglect, and traumatic experiences like domestic violence, bullying or abandonment. Trauma often leads to unhealthy attachments, where the person becomes either emotionally-alooof, or overly-reliant on others. Unresolved boundary breaches can create a damaging cycle of self-doubt and self-neglect.

KEY QUOTES

"Avoidance is a passive-aggressive way of expressing that you are tired of showing up."

"Assuming the worst is what most often stops us from even trying."

- People who are prone to anxiety often find it harder to manage their emotions and to honor others' boundaries. By contrast, people who are self-aware and adaptable are more likely to maintain and respect boundaries effectively.



Implementing Boundaries

There are 2 key parts involved in setting and maintaining boundaries:

- You must explicitly communicate your needs and expectations, rather than expect people to guess what you're thinking or feeling. For example, you can say, "It's important to me that you honor our plans. If you need to make changes, please call or message me a few hours in advance."
- Then, you must uphold your boundaries consistently with action. In the example above, if your friend tries to change plans at the last minute, decline and reschedule it 1 week later.



Communicating Your Boundaries



You can't resolve boundary issues by complaining, gossiping, avoiding, creating physical distance, or hoping for problems to disappear on their own. Avoid 4 common but ineffective ways to express boundaries:

- Passiveness: Ignoring your own needs and allowing others to do as they please.
- Aggression: Asserting your needs harshly, e.g. raising your voice, name-calling, or belittling others.
- Passive-Aggression: Acting out your unexpressed feelings, e.g. giving someone the cold shoulder even though you claim you're not upset.
- Manipulation: Forcing others to do what you want by withholding affection or inciting guilt/confusion.



The best way to convey your needs is to be assertive. State your needs respectfully, clearly, and precisely, keeping your tone calm

KEY QUOTES

"Assume that people know only what you tell them, honor only what you request, and can't read your mind."

"The truth is that unhealthy boundaries will follow you wherever you go unless you learn to verbalize them."

"People do not have to like, agree with, or understand your boundaries to respect them."

and your language simple. Use statements that begin with “I need,” “I want,” “I expect,” or “I would like.” Don’t offer any reasons for the boundary nor apologize for it.



After sharing the boundary, immediately address any discomfort you may feel, such as sadness, remorse, or guilt. Face the feelings rather than deny or dismiss them.

- To alleviate the feelings, engage in self-care activities like meditation, journaling, or walking.
- Reframe boundaries as positive tools to empower yourself and build healthier relationships.



Be prepared for resistance from others. Let’s imagine that you’ve just asked your colleague John to keep his side of the shared workspace tidier. John might:

- Push back: “What’s the big deal? You have your side and I have mine.” In this situation, reassert your boundary respectfully: “I understand it’s inconvenient for you, but I really need a clean workspace to focus.”
- Test your limits: John might clean up slightly, then let the clutter build up again. Stand firm, express your feelings, and restate your boundary, e.g. “I feel unsettled when my boundaries are tested. I’d like to reaffirm my request for a clean workspace.”
- Ignore your request: In this case, restate your boundary, invite him to repeat what you said to confirm his understanding, and point out if he ignores your boundary again.
- Challenge or question your reasons: Don’t try to explain yourself, as it could lead to a lengthy debate. Keep any response short and clear.
- Defend: If John gets defensive or tries to shift the blame, address one issue at a time using “I” statements to express your needs and feelings. For example, “When the workspace is cluttered, I feel stressed and unfocused.”
- Start ghosting you: If John starts to avoid you or stops responding to your calls/messages, send a note to express your observations, feelings, and concerns, e.g. “I noticed that you seem upset since our conversation. Can we discuss this?”

- Use the silent treatment: John becomes visibly cold and distant. In this case, respond in the same way for ghosting.
- Accept your boundary: This is the ideal and healthiest response, where John acknowledges your boundary and agrees to keep his workspace tidy.



Upholding and Maintaining Your Boundaries



Consistency is key. Uphold your boundaries without apology or compromise. Over time, both parties will adapt.

- If a boundary is violated, speak up immediately and restate your boundary. You can also express your feelings, re-emphasize your expectations, and ask them to paraphrase your request to ensure they've understood it.
- If someone repeatedly violates your boundaries, you can:
 - (i) Limit interaction: minimize contact, keep conversations brief, and listen without offering advice.
 - (ii) Issue an ultimatum, e.g. "If you show up unannounced again, I won't open the door."
 - (iii) Terminate the relationship if necessary. Only do this as a last resort after you've communicated your concerns, established your boundaries, and considered the relationship's positive aspects.
- In the event of conflicting boundaries, decide whether to compromise, maintain separate boundaries, or accept one side's boundaries.



Existing mental health issues can amplify boundary problems, and vice versa. Use these additional tips to cope:

- Anxiety usually comes from an inability to stand up for yourself, worrying excessively, setting unrealistic goals, and/or constantly comparing yourself with others.
 - Before making a commitment, ask yourself: Do you have the time/resources to undertake this? Whose expectations are you trying to meet? What's the worst outcome if you don't meet them? How can you uphold your boundaries?

KEY QUOTES

"Ending a relationship isn't a sign that you no longer care about the other person. It's an indicator of self-love, self-care, healthy boundaries, bravery, and your desire to be well."

"We can't create more time, but we can do less, delegate, or ask for help."

- Use positive affirmations such as: “I have the right to set expectations,” or “In a healthy relationship, my needs are acknowledged and respected.”
- Depression is often linked with feelings of hopelessness. Use small wins to instill hope.
 - Start with simple boundaries, e.g. correct a stranger who mispronounces your name, or request a redo if the restaurant gets your order wrong.
 - Use positive affirmations, such as: “I can honor small promises to myself” or “I can use small wins to achieve bigger ones.”

KEY QUOTES

“Healthy relationships are not one-sided. The needs of both individuals are equally important.”



Identifying and Managing Boundary Violations



Boundary violations can be big or small.

- Micro boundary violations seem trivial, but they accumulate over time to have a big impact. They include:
 - (i) Microaggressions: subtly-offensive responses about your behaviors or identity (e.g. gender, race). For example, someone may laugh at your accent or make remarks like: “I didn’t know you were gay. You don’t act like one.” You can point out the violation, e.g. “What does it mean when you say I don’t act like I’m gay?” Or, suggest a more respectful approach.
 - (ii) Oversharing: when someone shares too much personal information, e.g. a colleague sharing about her marital problems during a project discussion. You can redirect the discussion, or diplomatically request for a change of subject (e.g. “I’m uncomfortable with this discussion. Can we shift to another topic?”)
 - (iii) Guilt-tripping: when someone uses guilt to manipulate you into doing what they want. For example, you decline to go for drinks after work and your colleague says, “Our company isn’t good enough for you?” You can call them out on the manipulative comments or restate your choices without providing justifications.

- Macro boundary violations are persistent and can inflict long-term damage to relationships. They include:
 - (i) *Enmeshment*: where parties in a relationship have no personal space or sense of self. To counter this, re-establish physical space and individual identities, and take responsibility for personal problems.
 - (ii) *Codependency*: when you over-protect others, take on their problems, and justify their inappropriate behaviors. To set boundaries, clarify when/how you'll help, empower them to do things independently (rather than do it for them), and call out any toxic behaviors.
 - (iii) *Counter-dependency*: shutting others out even in healthy relationships. To set healthier boundaries, practice vulnerability, ask for help when needed, and accept help when it's offered.
 - (iv) *Trauma bonding*: when victims believe they're at fault for experiencing abuse or discomfort. They might say things like: "My partner gets angry and throws things when I ask too many questions. I must learn to figure things out on my own." To counter this, establish clear expectations of how you should be treated, and assert yourself when others say/do something that makes you uncomfortable.



Boundary violations can also occur across 6 different contexts:

- Physical boundary violations include: forced physical contact, standing too close, physical abuse, or privacy invasion. Set boundaries with statements like: "I'd prefer handshakes, not hugs" or "Please don't read my journal as it violates my privacy."
- Sexual boundary violations include: unwelcomed sexual acts/ touches, or inappropriate jokes and comments. Enforce boundaries with statements like: "Remove your hand from my thigh" or "Your comment is sexually inappropriate."
- Intellectual boundary violations include: belittling others' beliefs, laughing at someone's ideas, shouting during disagreements, or having age-inappropriate discussions. Assert boundaries with statements like: "I don't think this topic is suitable for a child" or "You can disagree without raising your voice."

"How they treat you is about who they are, not who you are."

KEY QUOTES

- Emotional boundary violations include: oversharing, emotional dumping, invalidating others' feelings, pressuring others to disclose personal info, or gossiping about others' personal lives. Set boundaries with statements like: "I don't feel comfortable talking about this" or "It's not okay for you to tell me how I should feel."
- Material boundary violations include: borrowing items without permission, or returning them in a worse condition. Establish boundaries with statements like: "You may borrow my car, but please return it by Friday with the tank full" or "Please ask for permission before using my things."
- Time boundary violations include: calling/texting late at night, expecting immediate assistance, or requesting free services. Set boundaries by saying: "I'm not available to discuss work after 8pm" or "I can assist with your presentation, but my fee is \$100."



Developing Self-Respect and Self-Discipline



You must respect and honor your own boundaries before expecting others to do so. Build self-discipline through healthy self-boundaries in various aspects of your life:

- Financial boundaries: Save, invest, and spend within your means. Don't lend money that you can't afford to lose.
- Time boundaries: Allocate your time based on priorities. Be punctual, plan ahead for each day, and consult your schedule before taking on new commitments.
- Self-care boundaries: Nurture your mind, body, and spirit. Decline engagements that don't align with your values or contribute to your growth and well-being.
- Internal boundaries: Monitor your self-talk and inner dialogue. Treat yourself kindly and coach yourself through challenges. Decide how you wish to handle difficult situations, e.g. to calm down before responding.
- Interpersonal boundaries: Consider how you allow others to treat you. If you feel exploited, ask yourself whether you've asserted your need for respect. Choose the type of people you want to spend time with.

"If you don't uphold your boundaries, others won't either."

"Self-discipline is the act of creating boundaries for yourself."

"It's your responsibility to care for yourself without excuses."

"People can ask you for anything, but it's up to you to maintain your boundaries."



Beware of self-sabotage and self-betrayal. Honor promises to yourself, uphold your values, focus on things within your control, and stop comparing with others.



Constantly refresh and restate your boundaries as you grow and evolve.



Applying Healthy Boundaries in Life



Family. Set boundaries respectfully with your family members, including: parents, in-laws, siblings, and children.

- Many adults find it hard to say “no” to their parents because they don’t want to disappoint them. Yet, misunderstandings and conflicts can arise from a lack of boundaries around personal space, privacy, participation in family events, or respect for your parenting style. Learn to verbalize your boundaries, e.g. “Sis and I are both adults. Please let us resolve our own conflicts.”
- Parents should also respect children’s boundaries.
 - (i) You can define limits and acceptable behaviors while recognizing their personal preferences. If your child dislikes certain food, clothing, or people, give them some healthy options instead of forcing them to your will.
 - (ii) Don’t ignore their requests when they say things like: “Can you stop saying nasty things about Mum?” or “Why are you always on your phone when we talk?”
 - (iii) Keep discussions age-appropriate. Don’t burden children with adult problems.
 - (iv) Role-model healthy boundaries by displaying self-care, self-discipline, and the ability to say/receive “no” as an answer.
- Family boundaries also extend to other areas including holiday arrangements (frequency, accommodation, time spent together), or interactions with siblings, uncles/aunties, grandparents, and other extended family members.



Romantic relationships: Seek a partner who shares your goals, values, and desires. Don’t expect him/her to change for you.

KEY QUOTES

“Don’t betray yourself to please others.”

“You become an adult when you set boundaries with your parents.”

“As difficult as it might seem, improving boundaries with your family is likely to create better relationships with them.”

- Communication can make or break a relationship
 - (i) Define what a healthy relationship looks like to you. What are your needs, and how can your partner fulfill them?
 - (ii) Discuss your mutual expectations as early as possible in the relationship. Consider questions like: Is this a monogamous relationship? Do you envision marriage? What are your deal-breakers? Pre-marital discussions should include financial and family planning, parenting styles, and familial relationships.
 - (iii) Create a safe space for open communication, and commit to address issues early before they escalate.
- Boundary-setting is especially crucial for a few challenging periods in a long-term relationship:
 - (i) *The first year*: Couples must navigate shared spaces, finances, and new roles. Challenges include: balancing personal time with multiple roles, splitting household tasks, and managing extended family relationships.
 - (ii) *Parenthood* changes the relationship dynamic from romantic to practical, and you must also align your parenting styles and philosophies. Ideally, discuss how you wish to maintain the relationship before the child arrives.
 - (iii) *Empty-nesters*: When the children grow up and leave home, the couple must re-establish routines and boundaries, and rekindle their relationship.



Friendships: Healthy friendships involve mutual support and acceptance, not competition and one-sided relationships.

- A common problem is when friends complain incessantly.
 - Typically, complaints fall into 3 categories: (i) venting to move on, (ii) seeking advice to solve a problem, or (iii) ruminating without any intent of resolving the issue. The last category is usually the problematic one.
 - To deal with a chronic complainer, you can: (i) change the subject, (ii) validate their feelings if appropriate, (iii) be honest if you're uneasy about providing advice, or (iv) set a time limit for such discussions.

KEY QUOTES

"We don't naturally fall into perfect relationships; we create them."

"Having uncomfortable conversations can save relationships."

"Open communication works best when done proactively before a small issue becomes a big problem."

"You can't re-create what you had before, but you can create something new."

KEY QUOTES

"Our relationships are a reflection of our boundaries or lack thereof."

"People will do what you allow, and they will do it over and over again until you stop them."

"All life changes require a shift in boundaries, and some relationships don't survive the changes."

"You can't outrun your inability to set boundaries."

- If you're usually the one complaining, be mindful about how often you do so, and use journaling to process your feelings. When you share your concerns with others, make it clear if you're venting or seeking advice.
- You can also set boundaries for other friendship challenges:
 - (i) If you're tired of acting as a relationship adviser, state so or redirect the conversation.
 - (ii) If you keep receiving unsolicited advice, share less or clarify upfront that you're venting (not seeking advice).
 - (iii) If your advice is repeatedly ignored, step back and let your friends learn from their own experiences.
 - (iv) If your friend often borrows money/possessions from you, it's ok to decline or set specific limits.
- Sometimes, it's better to end a friendship if it's toxic or you've simply outgrown it. Don't try to force things back to how they used to be, or to mend what's irreparable. If you've decided to end a friendship, you can let it fade naturally, cease all contact, or have a formal closing conversation. Choose the approach that fits the specific friendship.



Work: Overwhelm or burnout at work are signs of inadequate boundaries.

- Common work boundary issues include: overwork, unpaid overtime, constant gossiping, intrusive personal questions, discrimination, or sexual harassment. All these contribute to a toxic work environment.
- Changing jobs won't help unless you learn to set healthy work boundaries.
 - (i) Tackle the most draining/taxing aspects of your job first. Define the required boundaries and articulate your needs.
 - (ii) Document your workload, including dates and times. If possible, set limits for your workload and working hours, and resist working on weekends or during vacations.
 - (iii) Ask for help if you need it. Delegate wherever possible, and never offer your professional services for free.

- (iv) Instead of complaining about work, focus on issues you can address, and discuss work culture problems with your boss or HR department.
- (v) Set aside personal time before and after work each day. Take lunch breaks away from work, use vacation time to recharge, and explore interests outside work. Decide how far to participate in social events outside office hours.
- (vi) Build healthy relationships with supportive colleagues, and also seek support outside your workplace.



Technology and social media. Set digital boundaries to safeguard your focus, energy, productivity, and relationships.

- Signs of tech-overuse include: being constantly on your phone (even during work or social events), using your phone as a form of escape, and experiencing negative effects on your mental-emotional health.
- To control your digital intake and prevent tech overwhelm:
 - (i) Combat the fear of missing out (FOMO): redirect your energy to more meaningful activities like journaling or exercising.
 - (ii) When navigating social media, remember that it's impossible to please everyone. Instead of engaging in arguments, preserve your energy and unfollow/block/mute users who drain you. Only follow content that uplifts you, and skip over things that don't resonate.
 - (iii) Consider using a private account to control who follows you on social media (especially if you're an influencer). Establish clear boundaries with your online communities.
 - (iv) Limit your screen time. Set time blocks for the TV and Internet, and limit news to specific times of the day. Keep your phone away from your bed and start your day device-free. Or, set aside phone-free hours each day.
 - (v) Set tech rules for yourself and your family, e.g. no devices during dinners. Discuss relationship-specific boundaries with your partner, e.g. is it ok to interact online with exes or share about your relationship?

KEY QUOTES

"Just because you're at work doesn't mean you can't set limits."

"You can't please everyone, because everyone's needs are different."

"You are who you follow, what you watch, and the websites you visit."

"Some people feel entitled to your time, but your time is yours to manage."



Other Details in the Book to Look out For



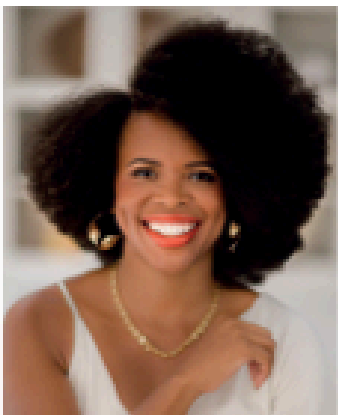
Remember: You can't control others' actions, but you can control how you react and what you tolerate. Boundaries in healthy relationships work both ways: you must set and enforce your boundaries while respecting others' boundaries. Use the ideas above to enhance your relationships and your well-being.



The book comes with many real-life examples, suggested words/phrases you can use, and checklists of behaviors and things to look out for. Each chapter comes with questions/exercises for reflection, and the book ends with a self-assessment quiz and a list of commonly asked questions. For more details and resources, please visit <https://www.nedratawwab.com>.



About the Author



Nedra Glover Tawwab is an American mental health therapist, social worker, and writer. She holds an undergraduate degree and master's of social work degree from Wayne State University. Tawwab began her therapy practice in Detroit and relocated to North Carolina where she opened Kaleidoscope Counseling. She's best known for her work on relationship health and boundaries.

KEY QUOTES

"Respecting other people's limits is a beautiful way to leverage respect for your own."